much support for Israel in the world. In short, the country is in many ways fighting for its existence or, more precisely, for its acceptance as a state like any other state.

What now mobilizes all news outlets—and rightly so—is the liberation of hostages. Hamas will almost certainly use the possibility of liberating further groups to extend the ceasefire from its original four days to a much longer period that will make a resumption of war very difficult. The organization can then claim victory, as it will emerge unbroken from a war that Israel proclaimed it would pursue until Hamas's complete destruction. For Israel the dilemma will be difficult. Yet even if it opts not to resume the fighting, Israel will have learned a very precious lesson: not to be caught sleeping anymore. And, in the meantime, to start working on a solution to the Palestinian problem, even if its implementation takes many years, possibly a whole generation.

Saturday, November 25

Another swap of fourteen hostages for forty-two Palestinian prisoners is supposed to take place today, although there seem to be some difficulties. Over the last two days, 400 trucks with humanitarian aid entered the enclave. Today a Qatar delegation arrived in Israel to discuss the possibility of prolonging the truce. There seems to be willingness on both sides.

Yesterday the Egyptian president spoke of the possibility of establishing a demilitarized Palestinian state including Gaza. It is possible in theory, but el-Sisi did not say where Hamas would be in the meantime. Does he imagine that Hamas will simply evacuate Gaza and allow for some other authority to govern the enclave? Or did he just say anything, for the occasion, which was a press conference with the prime ministers of Spain and Belgium?